Child Protection Policy

This policy sets out how Lifteracy safeguards children who engage with our programmes, platform, content, research, pilots, and partner-led activities.

1. Introduction

Lifteracy is committed to safeguarding the welfare, dignity, and rights of all children who engage with our work, including through digital learning tools, school partnerships, community programmes, and any in-person activities.

We recognise our responsibility to prevent harm, abuse, neglect, exploitation, and any inappropriate conduct (online or offline). We are committed to creating a safe, supportive, and respectful environment where children can learn and thrive.

This policy applies to all Lifteracy employees, volunteers, consultants, contractors, partners, and any other individuals or organisations acting on behalf of Lifteracy

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to:

- Protect children from harm in all Lifteracy activities, communications, and services.
- Set clear standards of behaviour and safe practice for anyone representing Lifteracy
- Provide simple, reliable processes for recognising and reporting safeguarding concerns.
- Promote a culture of awareness, vigilance, and accountability in safeguarding.
- Support compliance with applicable child protection and safeguarding standards and laws.

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All employees (full-time, part-time, temporary) and interns.
- Volunteers and consultants engaged by Lifteracy
- Partners, vendors, contractors, and other third parties who interact with children or have access to child data through Lifteracy
- All programmes, activities, and interactions involving children, including those conducted in schools, community settings, and via Lifteracy digital products (including messaging, audio, video, or any interactive features).

4. Definitions

- **Child**: Any person under 18 years of age.
- **Abuse**: Physical, emotional, sexual, or psychological harm, as well as neglect or exploitation of a child.

- **Safeguarding**: Measures taken to protect children from harm, abuse, and exploitation and to promote their well-being.
- **Child Protection Officer (CPO)**: The designated person responsible for overseeing safeguarding and child protection within Lifteracy
- **Child data**: Any personal data relating to a child (including name, contact details, school information, learning data, voice recordings, images, or any identifier), whether collected directly or via partners.

5. Policy Statement

Lifteracy is committed to:

- **Zero tolerance**: We have zero tolerance for any form of child abuse, exploitation, grooming, or harm.
- **Best interests of the child**: The best interests of the child are our primary consideration in all decisions and actions.
- **Prevention**: We take proactive measures to prevent harm and to identify and reduce safeguarding risks, including in digital environments.
- **Reporting**: We ensure that concerns are reported and addressed promptly and appropriately.
- **Empowerment**: We encourage children to express concerns and ensure they are listened to respectfully.
- **Privacy and confidentiality**: We protect children's information and treat safeguarding reports as confidential, shared only on a strict need-to-know basis and in line with our Privacy Policy.

6. Key Principles

- **Respect**: Treat all children with respect, dignity, and fairness.
- **Non-discrimination**: Ensure equal protection for all children, regardless of gender, religion, disability, caste, language, ethnicity, or socioeconomic background.
- **Child-centred practice**: Listen to children and consider their views in decisions that affect them.
- **Confidentiality**: Maintain confidentiality in all safeguarding matters, except where disclosure is necessary to protect a child or to comply with law.
- **Accountability**: Hold all staff, volunteers, and partners accountable for adherence to this policy and related procedures.
- **Do no harm**: Design programmes and technology so that they reduce risk and avoid exposing children to inappropriate content, contact, or data misuse.

7. Code of Conduct

All staff, volunteers, and partners must adhere to the following when interacting with children (online or offline):

- **Appropriate behaviour**: Be respectful, patient, and supportive; use age-appropriate language; maintain professional boundaries.

- **Physical contact**: Avoid physical contact that could be misinterpreted. Where contact is necessary for safety or care, it must be appropriate, minimal, and, where possible, in the presence of another adult.
- **Digital communication**: Communicate with children only through approved channels and official accounts. Do not initiate or continue private communication with children via personal phone numbers, personal social media, or direct messages.
- **Images and recordings**: Take or use photos, videos, or audio recordings of children only with appropriate consent and only for clearly defined purposes. Do not share children's media on personal devices/accounts.
- **Prohibited actions**: Never engage in physical, emotional, or sexual abuse; never exploit children for labour, financial gain, or any other purpose; never use corporal punishment, humiliating treatment, or threatening language.
- **Gifts and favouritism**: Do not offer gifts, money, or preferential treatment that could be construed as grooming or undue influence.
- **Data handling**: Access and process child data only as required for your role, and only using approved systems. Do not store child data on personal devices or share it with unauthorised persons.

8. Reporting and Response Procedures

- **Reporting concerns**: Anyone who suspects or witnesses abuse, neglect, exploitation, grooming, or any safeguarding risk must report it immediately to the CPO or via the whistleblowing mechanism.
- **Emergency situations**: If a child is in immediate danger, prioritise safety and contact local emergency services/appropriate authorities, then inform the CPO as soon as possible.
- **No independent investigations**: Do not investigate concerns yourself. Preserve any relevant information and refer the matter to the CPO.
- **Initial response**: The CPO will assess the report, take steps to reduce risk, and ensure the child’s safety.
- **Investigation and escalation**: The CPO will coordinate an impartial investigation and involve external authorities or safeguarding experts where required.
- **Support**: Provide or facilitate appropriate support for the child, which may include referral to counselling, medical care, and/or safe-guarding services.
- **Follow-up**: Monitor and review the situation to ensure ongoing safety and to strengthen controls to prevent recurrence.

9. Data Protection and Confidentiality

Lifteracy treats child safety information and child data as highly sensitive.

We commit that all personal data relating to children (and their caregivers/teachers, where applicable) will be kept confidential and private in accordance with our Privacy Policy and relevant internal data security procedures.

- **Data minimisation**: Collect only what is necessary for defined educational and safeguarding purposes.
- **Access controls**: Limit access to child data on a strict need-to-know basis; use role-based permissions wherever feasible.
- **Secure storage and transfer**: Store data in approved systems; use secure transmission methods for any data sharing with authorised partners.
- **Retention**: Retain child data only for as long as needed for the stated purpose and legal/contractual requirements, and then securely delete or anonymise it.
- **Confidential reporting**: Safeguarding reports will be documented and stored securely. Identities of the child and reporter will be protected as far as possible.
- **Incident management**: Any suspected data breach involving child data must be reported immediately to the CPO and the designated information security lead so appropriate containment, investigation, and notifications can be made.

10. Training and Awareness

Lifteracy will:

- Provide regular safeguarding training for all staff, volunteers, and partners (including digital safeguarding and safe online communication).
- Raise awareness among children, caregivers, teachers, and communities on child rights, safe learning, and reporting pathways.
- Ensure third parties who may access child data or engage with children receive appropriate onboarding and agree to safeguarding obligations.

11. Responsibilities

- **Child Protection Officer (CPO)**: Oversee implementation; receive and respond to reports; coordinate training; maintain records; review safeguarding risks.
- **Leadership**: Ensure safeguarding is prioritised; allocate resources; ensure partners meet safeguarding standards.
- **Staff, volunteers, and contractors**: Follow this policy and the Code of Conduct; report concerns promptly; participate in training.
- **Product, engineering, and data teams**: Build safeguarding and privacy-by-design features, including content controls, reporting tools, and appropriate data protection safeguards.

12. Review and Updates

This policy will be reviewed at least annually and updated as needed to reflect lessons learned, evolving risks (including digital risks), and changes to applicable laws, regulations, and organisational priorities.

13. Commitment and Approval

Lifteracy is committed to creating a safe and nurturing environment for all children. Every child has the right to learn free from harm, abuse, and exploitation.

This policy will be communicated to all employees, volunteers, partners, and stakeholders to ensure widespread understanding and adherence.

Approved by	Governing Body / Board of Directors
Date	25 Feb.
Authorised signatory	

Safeguarding contact (interim): tom@dignityeducation.org
Related policies: Privacy Policy; Whistleblowing Policy; Information Security Procedures; Code of Conduct.